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Week in Review: July 2-8

Jeff Cunningham

Welcome to Week in Review.

Let's see what's in the news today.

European Championships

The sixth annual European Championships took place last weekend in lovely London, England. 268 players competed in the tournament, including a multitude of pro players such as Kai Budde, Amiel Tenenbaum, and Tomi Walamies.

An interesting variation on the 3 rounds of Standard, 6 rounds of draft, 3 rounds of Standard format was used... 3 rounds of Standard, 7 rounds of draft, 3 rounds of Standard.

It was the first large tournament to use *Scourge* for Constructed, and there were some interesting new developments. Gabriel Nassif turned heads with his latest creation Ebony and Ivory, which utilized a whopping six Decrees. Kai Budde and Dirk Baberowski unveiled a dazzling Mind's Desire combo deck, and Jan Doise packed a hearty goblin deck with all the *Scourge* fixins'. You can find all of the decklists [here](#).



Pierre Mahlerbaud's camp dominated the first day of competition, with Mahlerbaud himself going 7-0 and teammate Karim Aouidad going 6-1. Pro Tour-New York winner Sigurd Eskeland, former European Champion Nicolai Herzog, Chicago Masters-winning Franck Canu, and two-time Pro Tour winner Tommi Hovi rounded out the rest of a strong 6-1 bracket.

Mahlerbaud continued his dominance during the second day, making it to 10-0 before losing to Herzog. After those two guaranteed their spots, Sigurd Eskeland, Stuart Wright of England, Thomas Shaw of France, Jussi Salovaara of Finland, Borot Todorovic of Sweden, and finally Gabriel Nassif added themselves to the Top 8.

The Top 8 contained a very diverse set of decks: two u-g, one r-g, w-r-g Astral Slide, monoblack control, zombies, Reanimator, and Nassif's w-b homebrew.

Gabriel Nassif's dominance of European tournaments continued with this tournament, but unfortunately, so did his curse. He has lost the last three of his Quarterfinals matches (two of them to players named Jensen). Hopefully, he will be able to shake his Sunday jitters in Berlin. He was defeated by Sigurd Eskeland, and cited having his eccentric decklist available to his opponent as a major factor in his defeat.

Mahlerbaud showed no sign of letting up, as his Reanimator tore Todoric's Slide "a new one".

Herzog's u-g (sans answer to Ensnaring Bridge) defeated a seemingly bad matchup in Wright's r-g (4 Bridges in sideboard) deck in four games to advance to the semifinals.

The Top 4 marked a return of Nordic dominance of the European Championships, with only Mahlerbaud hailing from outside the region.

Mahlerbaud's Reanimator defeated Eskeland's u-g in the Semifinals, despite Eskeland's deck being equipped to handle it. Sorry Siggy, you can't win 'em all. Herzog defeated Salovaara's zombies in the other matchup, which went to five close games.

Herzog took the Finals of the tournament 3-1, thanks to a strong matchup, sideboard, and draws.

Here is Nicolai's winning decklist:

U-G Madness		
Main Deck		Sideboard
10 Island	3 Roar of the Wurm	3 Phantom Centaur
2 City of Brass	4 Careful Study	2 Stupefying Touch
10 Forest	4 Circular Logic	1 Ray of Revelation
	3 Unsummon	1 Counterspell
22 land	3 Deep Analysis	1 Upheaval
	1 Ray of Revelation	3 Compost
4 Basking Rootwalla	2 Quiet Speculation	3 Ravenous Baloth
4 Wild Mongrel	1 Upheaval	1 Forest
4 Aquamoeba		
2 Arrogant Wurm	21 other spells	15 sideboard cards
1 Phantom Centaur		
2 Wonder		
17 creatures		

U-g wins another tournament, reinforcing the fact that I am a sheer genius.

Coverage for the event can be found [here](#).

Of Note

Hahnging On: Former Canada National Champion Jurgen Hahn has announced his intention to get back on the gravy train. He will be attending all the Grand Prix to support this effort (even the Japanese ones).

Your Move Games Online: Your Move Games, home to pro players Zvi Mowshowitz, Rob Dougherty, and Dave Humpherys, among others, has launched a website. The site features articles by many of the strongest players in the United States, and also sells the infamous YMG token cards. Add it to your favorites! www.YourMoveGames.com.

Worlds, Grand Prix-Atlanta to Allow Eighth Edition:

In a special exception to the rules regarding a set's legality for tournament play after its release, *Eighth Edition* will be allowed for both World Championships and Grand Prix-Atlanta. This means that **Searing Wind** will, in fact, be legal for Worlds. Now there's a card that gets all up in your grill.



Brazilian Boo-Boo Boo-Boo: In last week's error correction, Brazilian Boo-Boo I mistakenly corrected a so-called "mistake" pointed out by an unscrupulous reader; I said that Brazil was not a Latin country. Brazil is a Latin country.

Magic Online Avatar Selection to be Trimmed: In an effort to make the *Magic Online* avatars collectible, there will only be five free avatars available. However, there will also be several new avatars added, and given out as collectible, tradable, prizes for various online accomplishments.

Details regarding the new avatars and the reasoning behind this decision are available [here](#).

Magic Trivia:

The answer to last week's trivia question, "if there was a Constructed format using (minimum) forty card decks where the only cards legal were **Phantom Whelps** and islands, what configuration would be optimal? Why?" is, according to Gerard Fabiano, 28 **Phantom Whelps** and 22 islands. First of all, since there are only two cards in the format, it's a lot less relevant to keep deck-size to the minimum forty. As long as you have the proportions right, you'll want to garner an advantage by reducing your chances of running out of cards before your opponent. Second, you'll want a high land count, but not too high, so that you can respond to whatever strategy they're playing. If they come out aggro, you want to be able to block and trade Whelps and always have more in hand to play. However, you also want to be able to respond to a Draw-Whelp-Go strategy by having enough lands to play one... and a Whelp... per turn. It's also



important to have enough land to be able to replay many Whelps if necessary (should they go unblocked).

This week's question is: What occurrence is known, on the Pro Tour, as "Little Big Nug"?

Play of the Week: Brawler Gets Savaged



Morgan Douglass was playing in the finals of a **Magic Online Onslaught** Block draft, and down a game, with an average g-b deck against his opponent's monoblack monstrosity. At nine life, and with only a **Krosan Vorine** in play, Douglass was facing a double-amplified **Embalmed Brawler**, and two freshly morphed creatures. His opponent, only at 12 life due to self-inflicted damage, made a seemingly innocuous attack with just the Brawler. In response to the Brawler's attacking drawback going on the stack, Douglass cycled **Decree of Savagery**, putting four more +1/+1 counters on it! The zombie dealt six damage to its controller, putting him at 6, and knocked Douglass down to 1. Douglass untapped, and provoked the Brawler, forcing it to block and dealing the final six damage. Ouch.

Morgan Douglass, I award you Play of the Week!

Bad Play of the Week: Therapy Isn't Always the Answer

This week's Bad Play of the Week took place at this year's Grand Prix-Cleveland, with Kenny Hsiung (who would go on to a 7-0 record) playing against Robert Springer.

Hsiungs' u-b Upheaval Zombie Infestation deck had Springer's aggressive u-g in what can only be described as "the full lock": his **Zombie Infestation** and **Standstill** were the only cards in play. During his opponent's end step, Hsiung made a zombie token, and then untapped and flashed back **Cabal Therapy**. At his opponent's wide-eyed excitement, Hsiung immediately realized that his line of thought "flashbacks don't count as real spells", was woefully inaccurate, and said "actually - I won't". Springer responded "actually - you will".

Hsiung would later defend the play by noting that he won the match anyway. He would go on to finish 9th at the tournament.

Not winning when your opponent breaks their own **Standstill** is unforgivable.



When you play this, you don't

Robert Springer, I award you Bad Play of the Week.

want to be playing more spells.

Quote of the Week

"So, according to this, we're in Goblin Valley. Great. I mean, I mean, I mean... it couldn't be Happy Valley or Wonderful Valley. Goblin Valley. Why not, Axe Murderer's Valley?" - Fred Savage, from The Wizard

Next Week

- Grand Prix-Detroit
- Budde Call: Prank callin' Kai
- Pro Stories #1 - Gary Talim talks about his Pro Tour-Nice Top 8, and what led to his Quarterfinals exit



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